

BedSAT: Antarctica

Exploring what lies beneath using big data and modelling

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Aims

BedSAT: Antarctica is a modelling approach that combines satellite observations of the ice surface, airborne radar surveys of the bed, and numerical ice flow modelling. It is physically informed by observed bed morphometry statistics that feed into synthetic bedrock generation for Ice-sheet and Sea-level System Model (ISSM) [1] ice-sheet models. With BedSAT we aim to use machine learning to model bed-to-surface transfer from physics-based simulations over these synthetic beds. The goal is to invert the bed-to-surface transfer, so that observed surface expression from real satellite data can be mapped back to bed topography and generate a new Antarctic bed topography product with higher accuracy and resolution.

1.1 Project Deliverables

- **Paper 1 — ODSA:** develop Observational Data Spectral Analysis, a physically informed spectral framework for quantifying Antarctic subglacial landscape characteristics and classifying bed morphology into archetypes for ice sheet modelling.
- **Paper 2 — Bedrock factory:** design a synthetic bed topography generator for Antarctic landscapes that takes morphometric statistics from ODSA as inputs and produces bed realisations at ice sheet model resolution.
- **Paper 3 — BedSAT: Antarctica:** as described above.

Preliminary Literature review

Bed topography is one of the most crucial boundary conditions that influence ice flow and loss from the Antarctic Ice-Sheet (AIS) [2]. Bed topography datasets are typically generated from airborne radar echo sounding (RES) surveys, which are sparse and unevenly distributed across the Antarctic continent (Fig. 2.1). Interpolation schemes used to “gap fill” these sparse datasets yield bed topography estimates that have uncertainties of multiple hundreds of metres in elevation [2]. Some examples of these products are the Bedmap ice bed, surface and thickness gridded datasets for Antarctica [3–5], or BedMachine [6,7]. These uncertainties then propagate through simulations of AIS evolution under climate change [8]. Given the logistical challenges of accessing large parts of Antarctica, an opportunity lies in exploiting the vast wealth of underutilised high-resolution satellite surface observations including NASA’s Making Earth System Data Records for Use in Research Environments (MEaSUREs) [9] velocities and the Reference Elevation Model of Antarctica (REMA) elevations [10].

2.1 Approaches to Bed Topography Reconstruction

The generation of gridded bed topographies in Antarctica is based on two primary modelling approaches, forward and inverse models:

Forward models aim to understand how different bed properties influence ice flow. These often generate interpolated gridded topography using geostatistical techniques like kriging [11] and are valuable for investigating how uncertainties in the bed can impact outcomes like simulated ice mass loss. Forward models can generally be classed as elevation-preserving or texture-preserving (the bed’s geostatistical properties are maintained). Their limitation is the reliance on assumptions about the bed conditions rather than direct observation, so they explore possibilities instead of determining the actual topography.

Inverse models involve methods that assimilate other data sources and work by inferring bed properties, such as topography or basal slipperiness, from surface observations like ice elevation and velocity. Techniques like control method inversion [12] and 4dvar assimilation minimise mismatches between observed and simulated data [13]. On the other hand, mass conservation approaches use physical laws to reconstruct the bed, especially where measurements are sparse [2,6]. Despite their power, these methods face significant challenges. Variational approaches often require regularisation to prevent non-physical results and over-fitting [14], and time-dependent methods like 4dvar are computationally expensive, and probabilistic methods such as Markov Chain Monte Carlo (MCMC) quantify uncertainty well but remain too computationally intensive for large-scale models [14].

2.2 Quantifying Bed Morphometry

It is still uncommon for methods to systematically quantify the relationship between bed topography and its morphometric landscape statistics. Studies that measure the statistics report them as continuous fields, and terrain types are assigned to specific regions rather than to individual cells, with each parameter described qualitatively. Siegert et al. [15] define three bed roughness groups across named areas of East Antarctica, and Rippin et al. [16] assign three terrain types to the areas of their survey. Numerical thresholds have been published for single parameters, and Jordan et al. [17] divide the Hurst exponent at 0.5 and 0.75 to define low, medium and high roughness categories, but no scheme applies thresholds to a combination of axes per analysed cell. For published classified maps, each cell is often assigned to one class with no margin reported alongside it. Ockenden et al. [18] map the Antarctic bed into five landscape classes on 50 km cells, and the accompanying data release [19] records each assignment with no confidence interval or alternative class. Ambiguity in landscape class is usually acknowledged only as a caveat and is not quantified. The absence of margins makes such maps vulnerable to survey artefacts, like local roughness measurement bias due to radar migration status [15, 20, 21] or measurement limitations from the orientation and along-track sampling resolution due to uneven survey coverage [22].

Assigning a single class to a region or cell also averages the terrain within it. Rippin et al. [16] note that their large-scale grouping masks some complexities within the groups, and the selective erosion class of Ockenden et al. [18], which covers 56% of Antarctica, is defined as all topography that is not clearly “low-relief” or “alpine”. Such classes cannot capture the gradual change in roughness reported by Bingham and Siegert [23] or the continuum of landscape types described by Sugden [24].

2.3 From Signal Transfer to Tractable Inversion

Connecting observable surface features to the subglacial bed below while ensuring that the governing physics of ice-sheet flow are respected at the same time requires surface-bed transfer functions. The core principle behind a transfer function is that the ice-sheet acts as a physical filter, modifying the expression of bed features as they propagate to the surface. The work by Budd [25] established that ice preferentially dampens short-wavelength bed undulations while features with a wavelength approximately $3.3\times$ the ice thickness are most clearly expressed at the surface. This process also introduces a phase lag, and can be described mathematically using frequency-dependent transfer functions. More recent studies have built directly on this foundation. For instance, Gudmundsson and Raymond [26] refined the transfer function concept for ice streams, and Ockenden et al. [27] applied it in reverse, using full-Stokes transfer functions to invert high-resolution satellite observations of surface elevation and velocity to infer bed properties. These studies collectively establish that the physical relationship between the bed and the surface provides a viable pathway for subglacial mapping.

Despite the success of these approaches, their practical application has been limited by simplifying assumptions about ice physics. A primary limitation is the reliance on a linear (Newtonian) ice rheology, where stress is directly proportional to the strain rate (i.e., a “constant viscosity”). This assumption is often utilised to make the inversion mathematically tractable, but it contrasts with the widely accepted non-linear Glen’s Flow Law, where the stress exponent is typically $n \approx 3$ or even $n = 4$ [28]. Our results in previous work show that the choice of rheology is a critical control on the bed-to-surface signal transfer; a non-linear rheology ($n = 4$) produces markedly different surface expressions compared to a linear one ($n = 1$) [29]. By largely ignoring non-linear rheology and complex basal sliding conditions, past inversion

methods have introduced uncertainties and may not be robustly applicable across all dynamic regimes of the ice-sheet.

With Physics-Informed Machine Learning (Physics-ML), we can solve the computational bottleneck that has forced previous methods to rely on unrealistic simplifications. By leveraging NVIDIA PhysicsNeMo, a framework designed to blend governing physics (PDEs) with training data [30], BedSAT can learn the non-linear mapping between surface expressions and bed topography without linearising the physics. This approach is designed to transform what was previously computationally intractable into a fast, accurate inverse solver. Through an iterative process where initially inverted bed topography is integrated into forward models for progressive refinement, BedSAT will deliver physically consistent reconstructions validated against independent datasets.

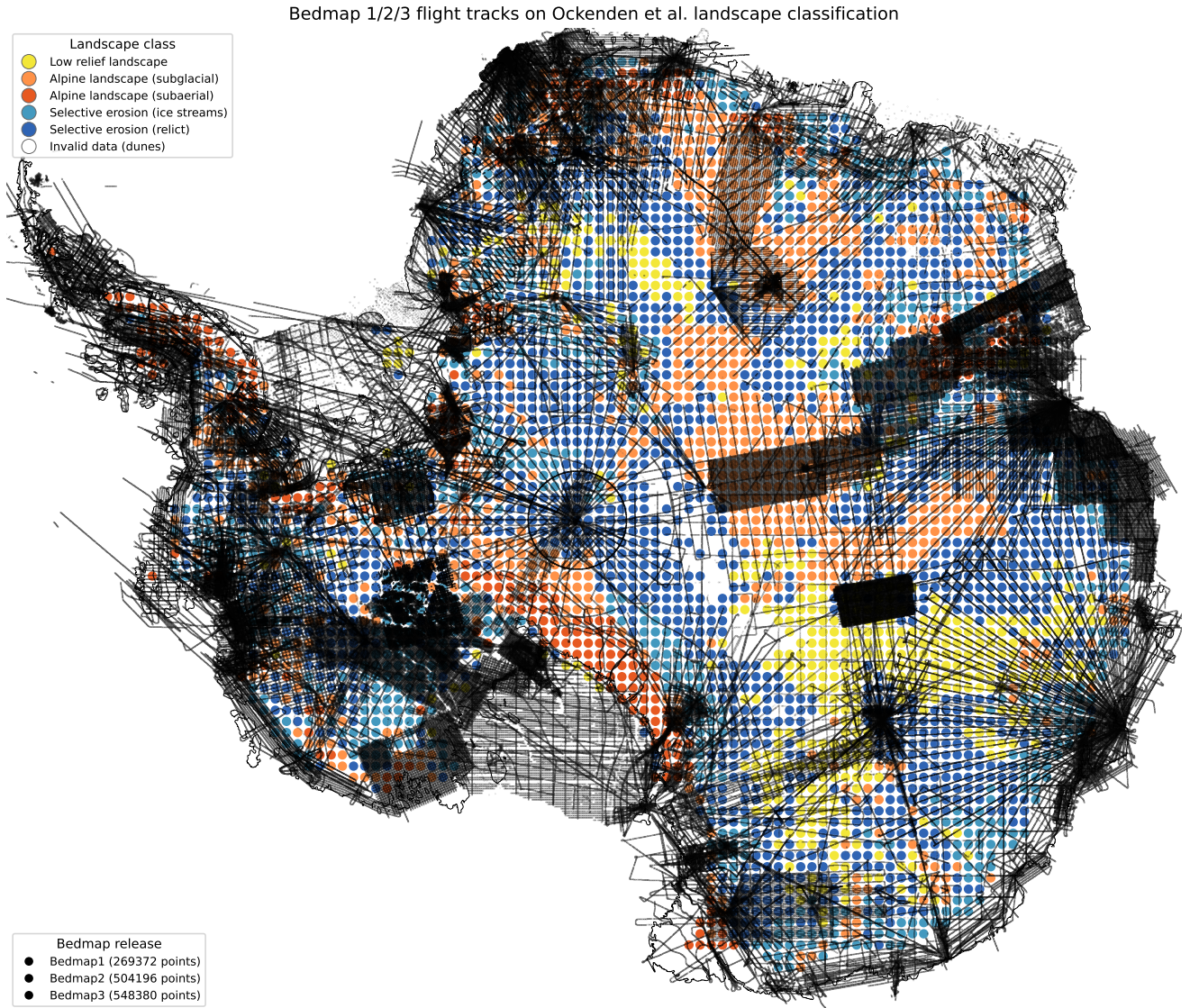


Figure 2.1: Bedmap1, Bedmap2 and Bedmap3 along-track survey points (black) over the continental landscape classification map by Ockenden et al. [18] (coloured cells, cells masked as invalid data (dunes) are drawn white). We reproduce the classification from the published metric grids [19] on 50 km cells. The point counts in the legend show the number of subsampled plotted points rather than published picks. ODSA operates on these along-track data, so the figure shows the sampling available to us across a continental landscape classification.

Research Significance

The accelerating loss of continental ice-sheets in both Greenland and Antarctica is a major contributor to global sea level rise [31]. Impacts extend beyond direct ice loss: as fresh water from melting ice-sheets is added into the ocean, it increases ocean stratification disrupting global thermohaline circulation [32]. In addition, cold freshwater can dissolve larger amounts of CO₂ than regular ocean water creating corrosive conditions for marine life [31]. While there is high confidence in current ice loss and retreat observations in many areas, there is more uncertainty about the mechanisms driving these changes and their future progression [33]. Uncertainty increases in regions with variable bed conditions, where characteristics like bed slipperiness and roughness have been difficult to verify via direct observations. Other problematic areas involve the ice-sheet grounding line (GL): the line where the ice-sheet is grounded on bedrock. The GL retreat rate depends crucially on topographical features like pinning points [33], which lead to buttressing of upstream flow. Although this mechanism is established, major knowledge gaps persist in mapping bed topography across Antarctic ice-sheet margins, with over half of all margin areas having insufficient data within 5 km of the grounding zone [34]. Addressing this data gap through systematic mapping enhanced by auxiliary data streams with more complete coverage would significantly improve both our understanding of current ice dynamics and the accuracy of ice-sheet models projecting future changes.

Subglacial bed roughness is already being used as a tool to infer basal processes and ice-sheet history [22], and it may provide information on basal drag, which is a key boundary condition for ice-sheet models [18]. In many regions of Antarctica the spacing between radar survey tracks is 10 to 100 km [18], but away from survey tracks, interpolated bed maps have not been able to reproduce the roughness of subglacial terrain observed along radar profiles [18]. A map like Bedmap3 with up to 93% of the 500 m ice-thickness grid cells filled with interpolated values [5] so the effective resolution is too coarse to be used directly in ice-sheet models.

As part of the first stage of BedSAT, ODSA quantifies subglacial landscape characteristics directly from the radar profiles. Previous studies have characterised bed roughness with one or two spectral parameters [15–17, 22, 35, 36]. ODSA describes each analysed window of a RES profile with a landscape vector of measured elements. Four of these elements are classifying axes or “classifiers” (Table 4.1). Each is divided into bands by thresholds, and a literature-informed catalogue of landscape archetypes is defined by bounds on these bands. The remaining vector elements are “descriptors” (Table 4.2). An analysed window will be reported as resolved, degenerate, out-of-catalogue or resolved-with-external. This last category means that the scheme cannot reduce the class because it is missing information that is fundamentally unobtainable from RES data alone. The ODSA pipeline names the axis responsible for the overlap and reports the observable required to break the tie (Table 4.3). These capabilities impact survey design by telling us which instrument to fly in a future survey. Additionally, bed texture decorrelation between nearby transects constrains the track spacing that is required to resolve a given landscape.

Project Methodology

4.1 Development of the BedSAT Inversion Framework

BedSAT’s goal is to leverage a physically informed transfer function with improved understanding of how ice rheology and basal sliding conditions affect the surface expression of subglacial topography. Its development requires the following stages.

1. **Training:** BedSAT will be trained and validated using a physically informed (ODSA) synthetic bedrock database (Bedrock Factory) and a data-rich region, such as the Aurora Subglacial Basin, where extensive ice-penetrating radar data of the bed is available for direct comparison.
Forward Ice Flow Model: The forward model of ice dynamics will be configured for the chosen study site, including key model assumptions, such as the choice of ice flow equations and the parameters governing ice rheology. The robustness of the numerical configuration will be confirmed through grid independence testing to ensure that the results are not an artefact of the model’s spatial resolution.
Inversion Pre-processing: The primary observational inputs for the model will be satellite-derived surface velocity, surface elevation [9, 10] and ice thickness [37, 38]. A critical pre-processing step will involve filtering high-frequency noise (e.g., aeolian features) from the surface data to ensure that the glaciological signal from the underlying bed is isolated.
2. **Inverse Modelling to Estimate Bed Topography:** The core of BedSAT is the inversion. BedSAT will iteratively adjust an initial estimate of the bed topography, aiming to minimise the mismatch between the forward model’s simulated surface velocities and the satellite-observed velocities.
3. **Validation and Sensitivity Analysis:** BedSAT’s performance will be rigorously evaluated. First, the inverted bed topography will be directly validated against the “ground-truth” radar-derived bed maps for the study region. Second, a series of sensitivity analyses will be conducted to quantify the model’s robustness. These tests will systematically alter key assumptions, such as the rheological parameters for different regions, to determine their impact on the final inverted topography and to establish the uncertainty bounds of the framework’s results.

4.2 ODSA’s Landscape Classification Vector

To inform the synthetic bedrock database that will be used in the training, we need bed morphometric statistics to describe a landscape class. We apply ODSA to seven reference regions as proof of concept (Fig. 4.1), quantifying how well the flight lines sample their survey footprint.



Figure 4.1: The seven RES survey regions we analysed with ODSA. Five regions use the PS71 boxes from [19] directly, while the Pensacola Pole Basin region and the Aurora low-relief region use boxes that we defined, with the Aurora low-relief region restricted to cells selected as low-relief from the published metric grids of [19].

Our proposal is that to bound subglacial landscape class it is necessary to have multiple measured statistics that characterise different landscape properties. Each classifier carries a $\pm 2\sigma$ envelope, from the spectral fit covariance for β and from measurement error budgets for relief, velocity and elevation. A window is admissible for an entry if its envelope overlaps the entry’s bounds, even when the central value lies outside them.

Table 4.1: Classification axes of the landscape classification vector. Across all four, the framework classifies each axis on value $\pm 2\sigma$, so a window can be admissible in more than one band.

Variable	Description/Thresholds
Classifiers β	Slope of the bed power spectrum over the fitted band (the first of two degrees of freedom obtained by the fit: β and A_{1km}). A measure of bed roughness shape: low β distributes power to the short wavelengths; high β concentrates it at long wavelengths. The fit band spans 250 m to 50 km. The classes are: chaotic < 1.5 , hard 1.5 to 2.0, transitional 2.0 to 2.5 and soft ≥ 2.5 . The 2.0 and 2.5 breaks follow the Hurst-exponent splits of [17]. The 1.5 break is an operational choice. Beds in the hard class are interpreted as scoured crystalline terrain, like in the areal-scouring landscapes of [24].
Relief	Elevation range within a window, calculated as $\max(\text{bed}) - \min(\text{bed})$ over the raw 50 km profile, in metres. It gives the amplitude of the largest structure a window contains. Regional slope enters the range directly. Relief classes are flat: < 350 m; mountainous: ≥ 800 m; while values in between these are labelled as subdued. These are set based on the median relief for the tested regions.
MEaSURES speed	Mean MEaSURES InSAR surface speed at the window’s track points, sampled over the same points that enter the spectral fit. Bands are very_low (< 5), low (5 to < 10), moderate (10 to < 50) and fast (≥ 50) all in m/yr and set operationally. Antarctic surface speed is bimodal, with a slow mode at 4 to 5 m/yr and a fast mode at 250 m/yr, and measured speed departs from internal deformation above about 15 m/yr [39]. Each window carries a sampled error from the ERRX/ERRY fields of that product [9].
Elevation	The mean bed elevation within a window, in metres above present-day sea level. Classes are submerged: < 0 m; elevated at ≥ 1000 m, and emerged for values in between. Motivated by [15, 16, 40].

Table 4.2: Descriptors of the landscape classification vector. These are continuous variables with no breaks.

Variable	Description
A_1km	$\log_{10}$ of bed power spectrum at a 1 km reference wavelength evaluated from the fit. It gives the magnitude of the roughness in $\log_{10}(\text{m}^3)$ and fixes the level inside the fitted wavelength band. It carries a propagated uncertainty that includes the slope and intercept covariance. The spectral fit returns two degrees of freedom (β and A_1km) following the conclusion established by [16, 17, 36].
RMS Roughness	Root mean square height [41] of the window's detrended elevation residuals, in metres. It gives the amplitude of the topography with the regional ramp removed, which distinguishes it from relief. It depends on profile length, and is retained for comparability with the space-domain roughness literature rather than as a separate degree of freedom.
ξ	Integral of the bed power spectrum over the bedform band from 300 m to 1200 m, in m^2 . ξ is the numerator of η [36]. Supported by [42, 43].
η	Characteristic wavelength for the window, in metres, following [36]. It is the square root of the weighted harmonic mean of the square of the wavelength at each frequency in the band from 300 m to 1200 m with the spectrum as the weight.
Hill count	Number of distinct local maxima in the window's detrended bed profile, similar to the bumpiness metric by [18] but in transect form (1D). A point counts if it is the maximum of a 5 km box centred on it and the box relief exceeds 20 m; adjacent flagged points count once and maxima touching a window edge are dropped. Two hills must be at least 2.5 km apart, so the count cannot exceed 20 per 50 km window.
Skewness	Third standardised moment of the window's detrended, untapered bed elevation residuals (bias-corrected). Positive values imply narrow highs on a broad low base, negative values mean narrow lows cut into a broad high surface, following the qualitative hills-against-troughs distinction in [24]. It is the only phase-asymmetry information in the vector.
Kurtosis	Excess kurtosis of the window's detrended, untapered bed elevation residuals (bias-corrected). Positive values mean a few extreme highs or lows against a flat background, negative values mean a flat-topped or evenly spread distribution.

Table 4.3: Observables that ODSA cannot supply from RES data. They are required to separate the admissible entries, or to confirm the entry on a row with one admissible entry.

External	Description
Reflectivity	Ice-water vs ice-sediment interface (specularity). Required by: BASIN. Separates: water from sediment under a flat, soft, submerged bed. Why ODSA can't measure it: needs raw radargram waveform amplitude.
Composition	Gravity / magnetics (sediment vs smooth bedrock). Required by: BASIN-HIGH. Separates: smooth hard bedrock from soft sediment. Why ODSA can't measure it: needs airborne gravity or magnetics
Flow history	Disrupted internal layers, dating (active vs relict). Required by: TRUNK-RELICT. Separates: TRUNK-RELICT from BASIN. Why ODSA can't measure it: needs disrupted internal layers or dating.
Origin	Erosional vs structural provenance of the trough-ridge contrast. Required by: DISSECTED. Separates: the three possible origins of DISSECTED, and DISSECTED from RIFT. Why ODSA can't measure it: needs independent geological context

Progress

5.1 Key research achieved (ODSA)

ODSA operates on the along-track picks published with Bedmap1 to 3 rather than a gridded product (Ch. 2). The tracks we use are shown in Fig. 2.1. The ODSA pipeline splits tracks into segments, cuts them into 50 km windows (when possible) with a 25 km step, applies a Hann taper, and fits the spectrum over 250 m to 50 km using a Lomb–Scargle periodogram. Fig. 5.1 shows a subset of ODSA’s catalogue, catalogue entries are paired with an analysed window in five of the seven regions in (Fig. 4.1) as proof of concept. We analysed a total of 651 windows, 650 of which fall in a classified (non-dune) cell. Our main results include: a transect bounds the landscape class but does not identify it with only RES data. Of the 11 catalogue entries, the median number still admissible per window is 2. The windows split into 402 degenerate, 135 resolved, 84 out-of-catalogue and 30 resolved-with-external.

In the case of our catalogue we found that a combination of our classifiers narrowed down the set of admissible landscape classes more than any single classifier for the windows analysed (Fig. 5.2). The figure shows the best combination at each number of classifiers. Resolved fraction peaks with β , relief and velocity (27%). Adding elevation lowers it to 25% and nearly doubles the out-of-catalogue rate, from 7% to 13%. However, elevation is the classifier that separates the most classes of the Ockenden et al. [18] classification (Fig. 5.3). Their classification is constructed from gridded bed elevation, so this is expected. Yet we found that no combination of our classifiers separates their alpine and selective-erosion classes from one another.

The classes reported by Ockenden et al. [18] are partly defined by roughness metrics (rms slope, hill counts, Fourier fractal dimension), yet over all valid 650 windows our roughness measures (β , relief, and the descriptors) barely separate them. A window can straddle two cells of different class. When we restricted to the 421 windows whose second-nearest cell carries the same class as the nearest, the seven descriptors together separate three of the six class pairs, including Alpine (subglacial) from Selective erosion (relict). The differing outcomes for roughness may be due to their classes resulting from an inverted, interpolated 2D grid (space-domain), while ours result from spectral measurements from 1D picks along track. The two roughness descriptions of the same ground therefore disagree, which is consistent with a gridded product not carrying the texture that a transect measures.

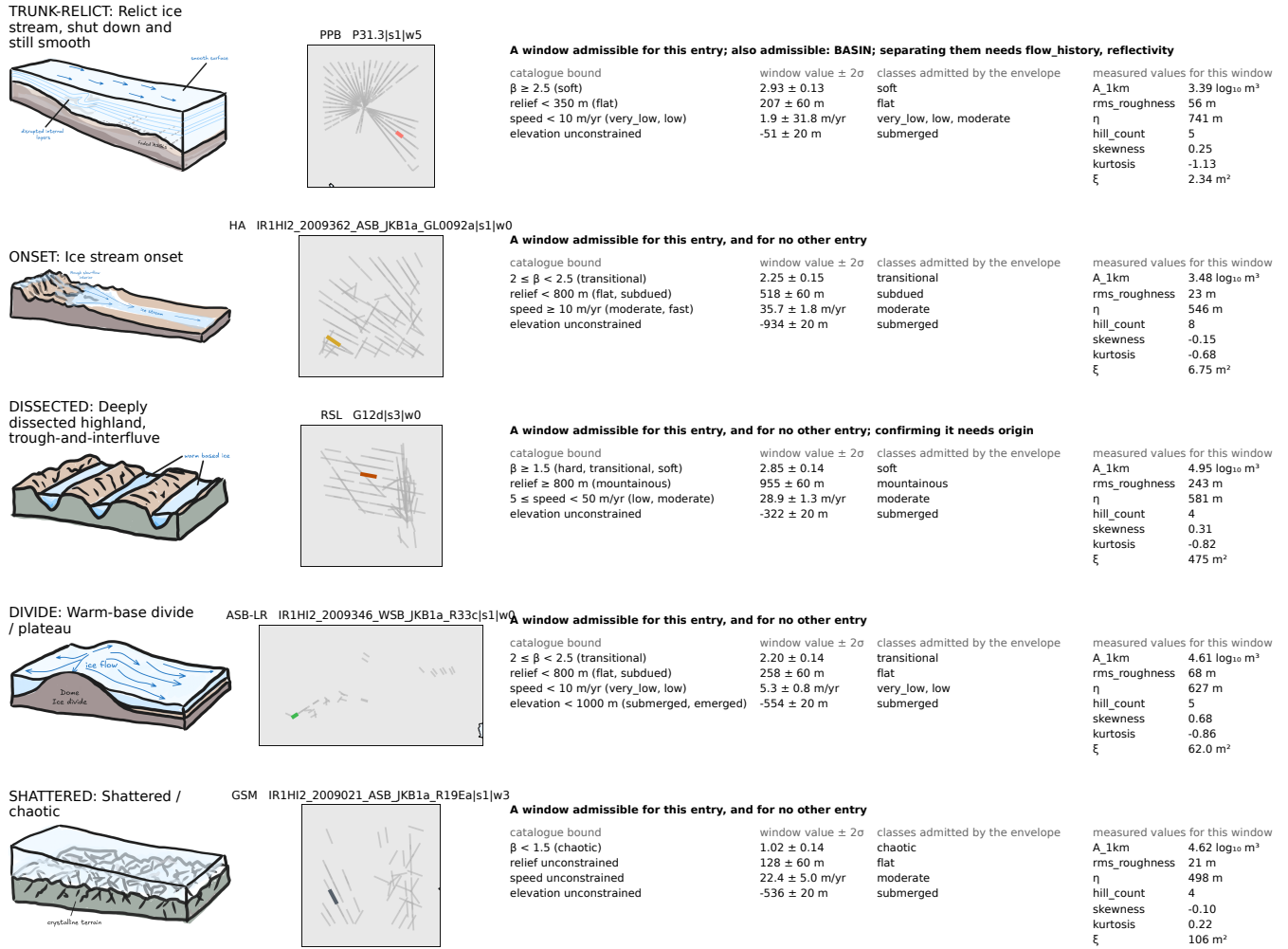


Figure 5.1: Five of the eleven catalogue entries, each paired with an admissible window, showing which entries the four classifying axes isolate and which they leave degenerate. Each row shows a window admissible for this entry, taken from the seven regions tested (Fig. 4.1). Admissibility does not claim that the archetype is correct. Left: the entry's cartoon exemplifying what that landscape may look like. Centre: the region's windows as 50 km along-track footprints in grey, and the example window in its archetype colour. The title gives the region and the window's unit ID. Right, first block: the entry's bound on each of the four classifying axes, the window's value with its envelope, and the classes admitted by that envelope. Right, second block: the window's measured values of the seven continuous descriptors. Rows with more than one admissible entry name the others. Externals named on a row are observables that ODSA cannot supply from RES data (Table 4.3).

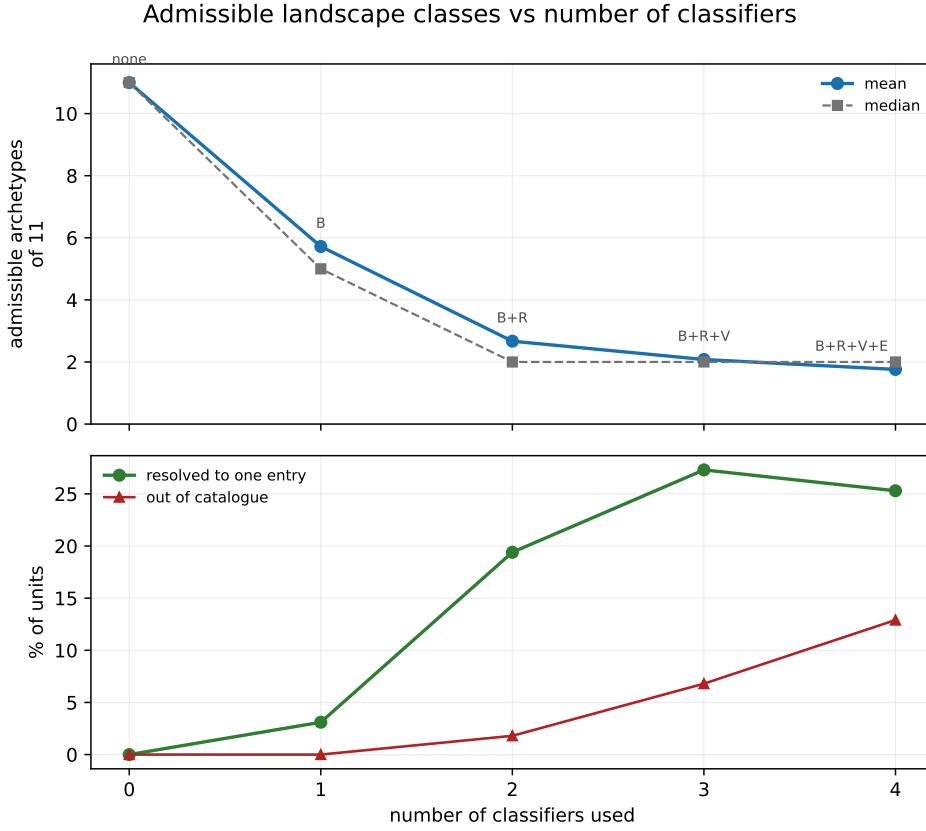


Figure 5.2: Best axis combination at each size (each unit is a window). β (B), relief (R), velocity (V), elevation (E). A window resolved to one entry has had the other ten excluded by its bounds; this is not an identification.

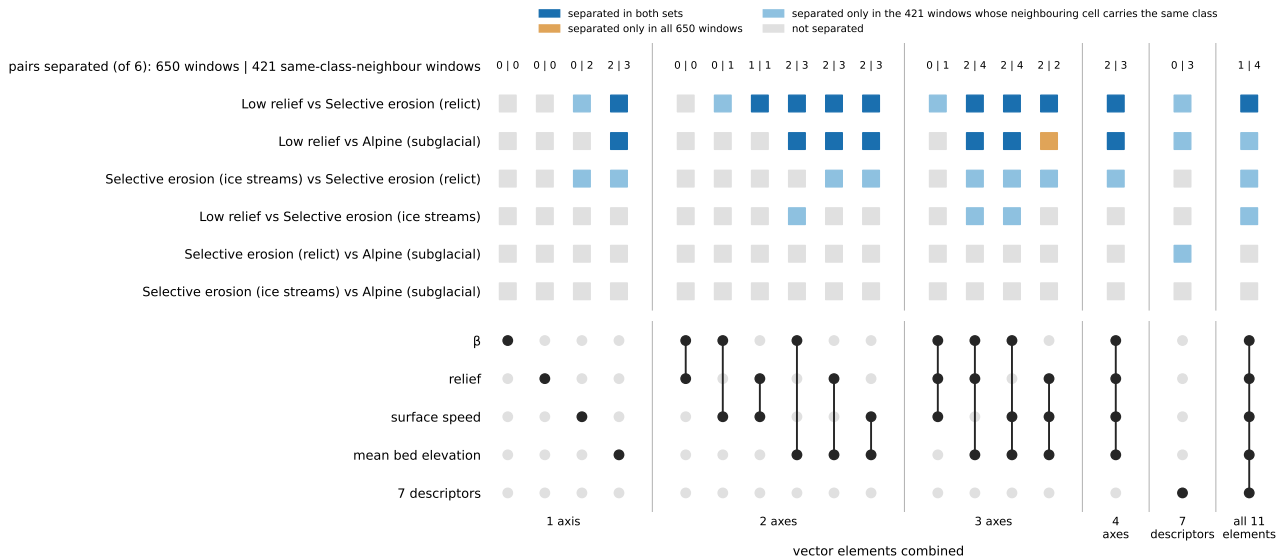


Figure 5.3: Separation of the Ockenden et al. [18] landscape classes by combinations of vector elements, over 650 analysed (non-dune) windows. Each column is one combination of the four classifying axes, the 7 descriptors together or all 11 elements together, and the black dots in the lower panel show the elements it uses. Square colour gives the two outcomes, and the numbers above each column are the counts of separated pairs in the two sets defined in the text (all 650 co-located windows, and the 421-window restricted set). Two classes are separated when the vector of their median differences is at least 1 pooled standard deviation long and at least a threshold number of standard errors long (depending on the number of elements in the combination), both measured with the covariance of the combined elements. Classes with fewer than 10 windows (Alpine (subaerial)) are not tested.

5.2 Thesis Progress Summary

We plan to submit a “Thesis Including Published Works”. The thesis chapters will include: an introduction, the three journal articles (papers) as outlined in Ch. 1, and a synthesis of the outputs for each as a conclusion. The current status in Fig. 5.4 for each of these thesis chapters is:

- **Introduction:** complete (pending additions for papers 2 and 3)
- **Paper 1 — ODSA:** code workflow exists, paper writing started in September 2026 and is in progress.
- **Paper 2 — Bedrock factory:** code exists, paper writing has not started.
- **Paper 3 — BedSAT: Antarctica:** code workflow does not exist, paper writing has not started.
- **Conclusion:** writing has not started.

The anticipated progress in the next 12 months includes finalising the writing of **Paper 1 — ODSA**, and continuing with the next stages of **Paper 2 — Bedrock factory**. However, the next 12 months of this project will be interrupted for 8 months total by maternity leave as shown in Fig. 5.4. The study load will also potentially be reduced to part-time after maternity leave ends, which moves the pending milestones for this project.

5.3 Resources

I require high performance computing resources (including compute and storage) from the National Computing Infrastructure (NCI). These resources are already available via a Flagship between NCI and the Monash-led Australian Research Council project Securing Antarctica’s Environmental Future (SAEF).

- **HPC time** for ISSM forward models.
- **GPU time** for PhysicsNeMo training (Forward model-ML and Inverse model-ML).
- **Software:** Python, ISSM and NVIDIA PhysicsNeMo.

Already accessed for **Paper 1 — ODSA:**

- **Data:** Bedmap1 to 3 [3–5], MEaSUREs speed [9], REMA [10], and Ockenden data release [19].
- **Software:** Python.

Data Management

Data will be published adhering to FAIR principles (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, Reusable), ensuring transparency and accessibility. The final bed topography datasets will be published at the Australian Antarctic Data Centre (AADC) under an open licence. All production model outputs will be published with unique DOIs at repositories aligned with the corresponding papers. Model outputs will be archived to tape at NCI using existing SAEF resources, as well

as backed up to storage available through Monash MASSIVE M3 account aligned with project supervisor Dr McCormack. All papers published through this project will be open access, and tier 1 journals will be targeted.

5.4 Timeline

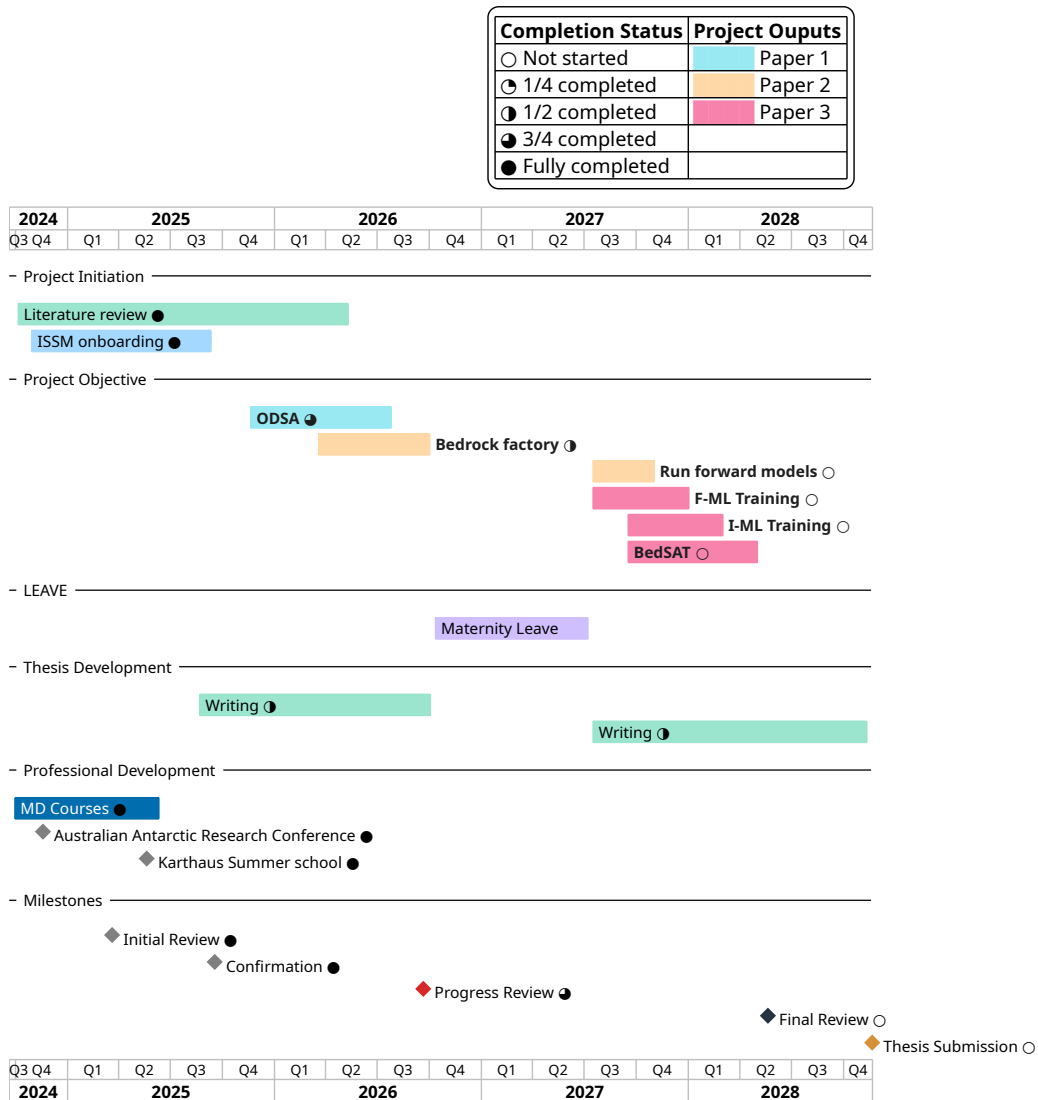


Figure 5.4: Project timeline. In the Project Objective section, the colour of each bar shows which paper the task contributes to. Completion status for each task and what it means: quarter-filled—the code workflow exists, half-filled—results pending, three-quarter—results are complete with write-up pending.

Word count:

(171 / 200) words in Aims,
(1051 / 1500) words in Preliminary Literature Review,
(498 / 500) words in Research Significance,
(411 / 500) words in Project Methodology,
(749 / 500) words in Progress.
actual total words = 2880 (not including captions)
allowed total words = 3200

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